

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

Pastor Richmond Kobe

FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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Contact: info@faithfulpathcommunity.com

SESSION EIGHT

Rediscovering Your Identity

Flex session: Day 3 afternoon if there is capacity, otherwise in the 30-day plan

Before you begin

This is a flex session. If you have come to it on Day 3 with energy to spare, welcome. If you are reading it three weeks later at your kitchen table, also welcome; it was written with both of you in mind. Nothing here depends on the retreat setting except a little quiet.

It is gentler than the Day 2 sessions. Its subject is who you are when the roles are set aside for a moment, and for many burned-out people that question is uncomfortable not because it is painful but because they have never had time to ask it.

Central passage

Matthew 3:13–17, followed by **Matthew 4:1–11** Read both passages once, in sequence. Then read 3:17 again on its own.

Teaching

Before Jesus began his public ministry, before the recorded sermons, healings, miracles, and calling of disciples, he was baptised in the Jordan, and a voice from heaven said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased."

Notice the timing. The declaration comes before the public work. Jesus had already lived many years of faithful human life; Luke 2 shows him growing, worshipping, and living obediently within his family. But he did not earn or acquire his sonship through public performance. The baptismal declaration identifies who he already is. His later obedience expresses that identity; it does not manufacture it.

Then notice what happens immediately afterwards. Matthew 4 opens with Jesus led into the wilderness, and twice the tempter begins, "If you are the Son of God..." The temptations invite Jesus to use sonship on the tempter's terms: satisfy hunger through power, stage a spectacle, demand that God prove his protection, and finally take the kingdoms by bowing to someone other than the Father. The implication is: if you are the Son of God, prove it on these terms. Jesus refuses to turn identity into self-serving performance, answers from Scripture, and remains obedient. The sonship was never in question, and he does not need to demonstrate it.

I begin here because burnout may expose how closely a person's worth has become attached to usefulness, achievement, or being needed. That does not mean identity caused the burnout; Chapter 4 was clear that burnout has structural causes, and this session does not replace that. It means exhaustion can reveal a dependence that was harder to notice while the role was going well. As long as the doing continues, the sense of self holds. When the doing falters, through exhaustion, illness, redundancy, a child leaving home, retirement, or the end of a ministry, the question "who am I if I am not doing this?" arrives, and it can be frightening, because there may be no answer ready.

The baptismal declaration belongs uniquely to Jesus, the eternal and beloved Son. Christians do not become children of God in precisely the same way he is the Son. Yet through union with

Christ and the Spirit of adoption, those who belong to him are truly welcomed into God's family. **1 John 3:1**: "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are." Not "so we will be, once we have done enough." So we are. **Galatians 4:6-7** adds: "because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, 'Abba! Father!'" So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God." Paul's immediate contrast concerns slavery under the law and adoption as heirs through Christ, and his legal adoption imagery includes women and men alike as heirs. The image nevertheless challenges performance-based belonging: the believer's place in God's family is received through Christ, not earned through usefulness. The Spirit in the believer cries "Father," which is a cry of belonging, not of performance.

This does not mean roles are unimportant, or that you should feel nothing when one ends. You are a parent, or a pastor, or a nurse, or a provider, and those are real callings with real weight, and losing one is a real loss that Session Four gave you room to grieve. A deeper identity in Christ can provide a foundation when a role changes or ends. It does not eliminate grief or disorientation, and spiritually mature people still experience both. But it reminds the person that the role was never the whole of who they were. Without that foundation, a person may experience the end of a role as though the self has disappeared with it.

A caution. This session is not based on unsupported positive thinking or the idea that repeating flattering statements can create reality. It is grounded in what Scripture says about belonging to Christ, which is true whether or not you feel it. Psychological care and healthy self-regard are not competitors with that truth. And if worthlessness is persistent, affects many areas of life, interferes with daily functioning, or accompanies

hopelessness, loss of interest, major changes in sleep or appetite, or thoughts of death, seek professional care. You do not need to wait until it becomes severe. Chapter 5 applies.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. List the roles you hold: family, work, church, community. All of them, including the informal ones, like "the one who holds everyone together." This is not asking you to erase your relational or vocational identity; "parent," "pastor," "friend," and "neighbour" describe real relationships and responsibilities. The question is whether any one role has become the sole measure of your worth.
2. Beside each, mark honestly how much of your sense of worth rests on it. A little, some, or a great deal.
3. Which role, if it ended tomorrow, would leave you least sure who you are?
4. If you could not mention achievements, productivity, income, influence, or how useful you are to others, what would you want someone to understand about you? Try to write two sentences.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

*Father, before Jesus began his public ministry, you
declared him to be your beloved Son.*

*Through him, you have adopted me and called me your
child.*

*I have sometimes measured my worth by usefulness,
approval, and achievement, and it has made me tired,
because I never get to stop.*

*Help me recognise what is true without denying the importance of my callings.
Let my roles grow from belonging rather than becoming the price of belonging.
Teach me to serve without making service the measure of whether I am loved.
Amen.*

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: **"See what love the Father has given us."** Or: **"Abba, Father."** If parental language is difficult for you because of your own history, use instead: **"Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ."**

In this silence, you are not producing, solving, or proving anything. You may sit, stand, walk slowly, or use gentle movement while remaining with the passage. Each time your mind reaches for a task, a role, or a reason to be useful, notice it, and return to the phrase. If the phrase feels inaccessible, do not force yourself to claim an emotional certainty you do not have. Read the verse as Scripture, "You call your people children of God," or pray, "Help me understand what adoption in Christ means for me." If it triggers severe distress, pause the session, and bring what happened to someone you trust.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What happened when you tried to be rather than do in the silence? Restlessness, relief, discomfort, blankness? Write it down.
2. The tempter's challenge carried the implication, "Prove who you are on these terms." Where have you been trying to prove your worth through achievement, usefulness, visibility, or sacrifice?
3. Which role could you hold with less fear or compulsion if you trusted that it was not the source of your worth? Is there any optional responsibility that may need to be reduced, delegated, or released?
4. Is there a loss of role, past or approaching, that you have been treating as a loss of self? Name it.

Practical exercise: what I do, what matters, what remains

Take a page in your journal and make three columns.

What I do	What matters about this role	What remains true beyond this role
Pastor	Teaching and caring for people	I remain God's child and part of Christ's body when I am not preaching
Parent	Loving and protecting my children	My worth is not measured by my children's choices
Provider	Supporting my household	Income and usefulness are not the price of God's love

Fill in your own roles. The first column you already know. The second column honours what the role genuinely is; do not skip it.

The third column is the work of the exercise: for each role, what remains true of you, in Christ, if the role changed or ended?

To fill the third column, draw on what Scripture says is true of those who belong to Christ, in your own words, with the references. Do not invent these; find them. Some to start from:

- Created in God's image (Genesis 1:27)
- A child of God (1 John 3:1)
- Loved by God while still a sinner; his love was not earned by my improvement (Romans 5:8)
- Not condemned (Romans 8:1)
- Adopted, not enslaved (Galatians 4:7)
- Chosen in Christ for holiness (Ephesians 1:4)
- A recipient of grace, not self-made (Ephesians 2:8–10)
- Part of Christ's body, with gifts and limits (1 Corinthians 12:12–27)
- Called to love God and neighbour (Matthew 22:37–39)
- A work in progress under God's care (Philippians 1:6)
- Not separated from God's love by anything (Romans 8:38–39)
- Not left or forsaken by God (Hebrews 13:5) When the page is done, look at it whole. Then, on an index card, copy the three or four lines from the third column that you most needed to read. Read the card aloud, if you have privacy, as a statement of what is true rather than what you feel. Keep it. This card goes home with you too, and it belongs somewhere you will see it on the day a role ends, or a task fails, or someone stops needing you. Keep it where it is both useful and private; if displaying Christian material or personal writing could create conflict or danger, store it securely or use a neutral phrase.

If the third column felt inaccessible, identify why: emotional numbness, theological uncertainty, painful experiences with

parental language, doubt about belonging to Christ, or simply unfamiliarity. Do not force certainty. Bring the page to a mature and safe Christian guide who will listen rather than pressure you. Some truths need to be spoken by someone else before they can be received.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

*Before Jesus began his work, the Father called him
beloved; through him, I am called God's child.
What I do rests on who I am, not the other way round.
My roles matter, and they are not the measure of my
worth.
I am not a slave who must stay useful.
I am a child who is loved.*

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

After Session Eight: if you are on Day 3, take a break before deciding whether to do Session Nine. Purpose and identity belong together, and Nine builds on this session, but it is also fine to leave it for the 30-day plan and go to Session Ten rested. If it feels safe and useful, share one line from your third column with your support person. You are not required to share the entire page.